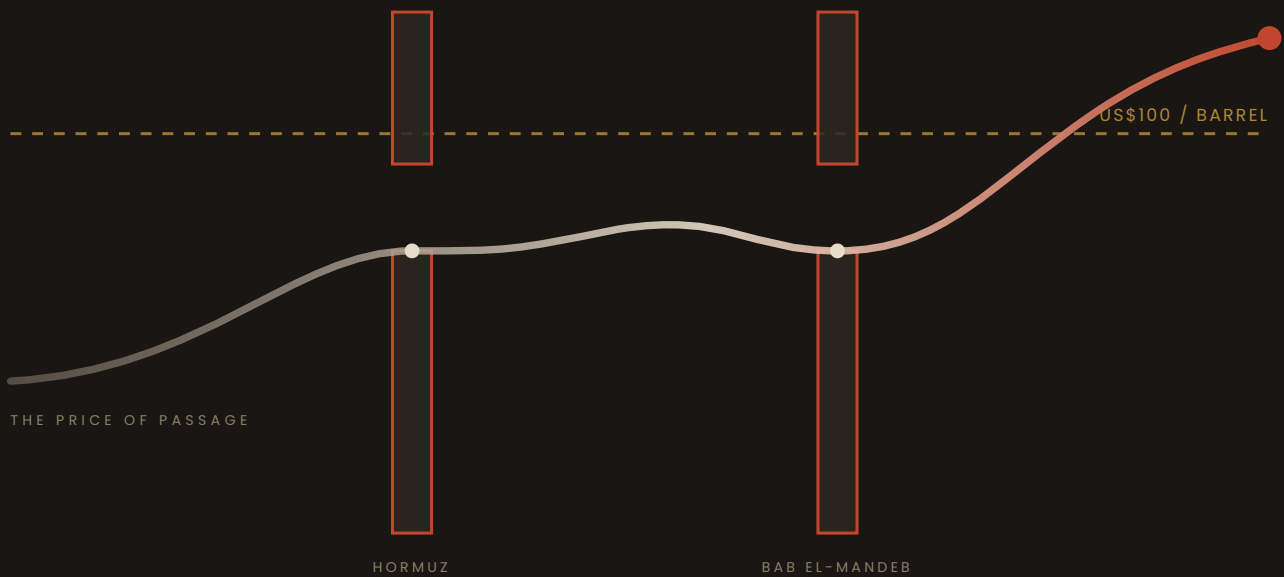


THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.



THE WORLD

Three tankers hit in a single day drive Brent past \$100 as the Gulf war grips both straits at once

TECHNOLOGY

Nvidia's compliance net tightens on Asia — and quietly names Singapore its problem

SINGAPORE

A younger Cabinet is sworn in on Monday as a strong GDP print hides a slowing trade cycle

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FROM THE DESK

"Man is least himself when he talks in his own person. Give him a mask, and he will tell you the truth."

— **Oscar Wilde, *The Critic as Artist* (1891)¹**

Wilde meant art; the issue keeps proving him in life. In China, a generation covers its bags in enamel pins until the display is deliberately "painful" — a mask of fandom that says, more honestly than any words, what a stalled economy feels like from the inside (p21). On the dating apps a cohort exhausted by performance is deleting them to be seen plainly (p17). Even the markets did it: oil broke \$100 not on the barrels actually lost but on the fear the next tanker made visible (p3). The mask, Wilde knew, is where the truth leaks out.

BRENT CRUDE

>\$100 ▲

GOLD (XAU)

~\$4,050 ▲

BITCOIN

~\$65k ▼

USD/SGD

1.2917

US 10-YEAR

4.66% ▲

THE MERIDIAN INDEX

FRIDAY · THE WEEK IN NUMBERS

Dollars a barrel Brent crude reached, first time since spring	100 — p3
Tankers struck in a single day across the war's two straits	3 — p3
Percent tariff the US put on most Canadian goods	50 — p4
Percent Singapore's June export growth was forecast to be	30.2 — p5
Percent it actually was	20.7 — p5
Indicative S\$ psf at Turf City's first private condo	2,799 — p6
Percent of Nvidia's approved Asian chip buyers it just cut	>50 — p7
Percent of lots sold at the best watch auction in history	99.8 — p11

Percent of those bidders buying for the first time	40 — p11
Percent of adolescent well-being that screen use explains	0.4 — p14
Market-priced chance of a US rate hike by September	61% — p15
Billions of years old the departing interstellar comet is	~7 — p16
Percent of young adults who are actively dating	31 — p17
Average US dollars a first date now costs	189 — p17
Billions of US dollars in China's "emotional-value" merch economy	~24 — p21
Percent of its buyers who say the merch gives them "companionship"	83 — p22

SOURCES ¹ Oscar Wilde, *The Critic as Artist* (1891). The Meridian Index: figures harvested from this issue, each keyed to its desk page; see the cited SOURCES there. Market strip: CNBC, TradingEconomics, Bloomberg — levels as of 23 Jul 2026, subject to change by press time; the BTC print is single-sourced and held lightly (p15).

THE WORLD · THE GULF WAR, DAY 32

Oil Breaks \$100 as the War Comes for the Tankers

Three ships were hit inside a single day — two in the Red Sea, one at the mouth of Hormuz — and the number the whole world watches finally gave way: Brent crossed a hundred dollars for the first time since spring.

For four months the Gulf war had threatened the oil price without quite breaking it. On Thursday it broke it. Three tankers were struck in roughly twenty-four hours: the Houthis said they hit two Saudi-bound vessels in the Red Sea — the first shots fired in anger to enforce the Bab el-Mandeb blockade they declared on 20 July — while at the far end of the theatre Iran's navy claimed a strike on the Marshall Islands-flagged *Safesea Vishnu* near Kumzar, at the very mouth of the Strait of Hormuz.¹ Both chokepoints, the two narrows through which the tankers of the world are physically obliged to pass, were now live fire zones at once.

The market did what a market does when two straits are shooting: it panicked on the fear, not the tonnage lost. Brent jumped past US\$100 intraday — its first three-figure print since May — before settling in a US\$98–101 band; West Texas followed to about US\$90, the highest since 8 June.² This is a war premium, an insurance premium and an inflation premium in one barrel, and its real weight lands not in the Gulf but on the world's central banks (p15). The

strikes ran in parallel to the campaign: US forces pressed a twelfth consecutive night of attacks, and President Trump formalised his terms — one Iranian bridge or power plant destroyed for every ship fired on in Hormuz, targets including sites "next to, or in, Tehran."³

\$100

BRENT CRUDE CROSSED A HUNDRED DOLLARS A BARREL FOR THE FIRST TIME SINCE SPRING, AFTER THREE TANKERS WERE STRUCK IN A SINGLE DAY ACROSS THE WAR'S TWO STRAITS.

A door out remains propped open, barely. Mediators from Qatar, Egypt, Pakistan and Oman have put a ten-day ceasefire on the table — a halt to hostilities and a reopening of Hormuz, meant to salvage the fourteen-point June memorandum both capitals signed in spirit and neither has honoured.⁴ Washington says it wants a *longer* truce and is "preparing for the possible failure" of this one; Tehran has not said yes. Neither has said the word that would stop it. See p15.

TWO STRAITS

OIL OVER \$100

TRUCE STALLED

WASHINGTON

DETERRENCE FRAMING

The White House frames the escalation as symmetry, not aggression: every attack on a ship in Hormuz, Trump says, will be answered by a strike on "an Iranian bridge or power plant." Secretary of State Rubio warned that Tehran's threat to the strait "risks global fallout," casting the campaign as the defence of a passage the whole world depends on rather than a war of choice.⁵

TEHRAN

TASNIM / STATE FRAMING

Iranian state media answers threat with threat. An unnamed military source told Tasnim that if the US targets "a bridge or a power plant in Iran, Iran will, in turn, strike infrastructure and bridges in the region, including energy facilities where the United States has interests" — recasting Hormuz as sovereign water and any strike on Iranian civilian sites as the crime.⁶

THE SCEPTIC

The word "blockade" is doing more work than the guns. The Foundation for Defense of Democracies notes that ships are mostly *rerouting pre-emptively* rather than being sunk en masse — so far the supply shock is largely a risk-and-insurance premium, not a physical closure of the strait.⁷ The \$100 barrel is priced off what might happen to the next tanker, not the barrels actually lost from this one. Real, but not yet the catastrophe the number implies.

SOURCES 1 CNBC, "Oil prices jump as Trump-Iran tensions grip Hormuz," 23 Jul 2026; Al Jazeera, "Yemen's Houthis declare naval blockade of Saudi Arabia," 20 Jul 2026 (Houthi enforcement; *Safesea Vishnu* claim). 2 CNBC oil report, 23 Jul 2026 (Brent >\$100 intraday; WTI ~\$90, highest since 8 Jun). 3 CNBC, "Trump vows to bomb Iran's bridges, power plants..." 22 Jul 2026 (12th consecutive night; targets in Tehran). 4 The New Arab, "Qatar and Pakistan propose 10-day Iran-US ceasefire," 21 Jul 2026 (Qatar/Egypt/Pakistan/Oman; US wants longer truce, "preparing for possible failure"). 5 CNBC, 22 Jul 2026 (Trump; Rubio, "risks global fallout"). 6 Tasnim via CNBC liveblog, 22 Jul 2026 (Iranian military source). 7 FDD, "Houthis announce blockade of Saudi Arabia; ships reroute to avoid Bab al-Mandeb," 22 Jul 2026.

WASHINGTON SIGNS A NUCLEAR PACT WITH RIYADH — MID-WAR

The war did not stop the deal-making. On 23 July the US Department of Energy confirmed a commercial civil-nuclear cooperation pact with Saudi Arabia — the legal scaffolding for a partnership Washington casts as decades long.¹ President Trump insists the text bars Saudi enrichment on its own soil and made the whole thing "totally subject" to Riyadh joining the Abraham Accords and normalising with Israel. Critics are unconvinced on both counts: Senator Ed Markey accused the President of "caving," and analysts note the agreement does not obviously forbid using US technology to enrich third-country fuel, nor mandate tighter IAEA oversight.² Israel is alarmed regardless — a nuclear-capable neighbour is a nuclear-capable neighbour, whatever the annex says.

UKRAINE'S NEW COMMAND TURNS THE WAR NORTH

Kyiv's military leadership was remade this fortnight and has already set its heading. Yevhen Khmara took over as acting defence minister under a directive in force from 20 July, after Rustem Fedorov was pushed out; Mykhailo Drapatyi was named commander-in-chief on 21 July, replacing Oleksandr Syrskyi.³ The two met on 22 July and agreed the priority is long-range strikes on Russian soil — "transferring the war to the aggressor's land." It advances, rather than reopens, the reshuffle tracked since No. 46; Rada confirmation of Khmara is still pending.

CONGO'S EBOLA PASSES A THOUSAND DEAD

The Bundibugyo-strain outbreak declared in eastern Congo on 15 May crossed a thousand deaths this week: 2,473 confirmed cases and, by the latest count, 1,031 deaths, in what the WHO still calls the fastest-spreading

Ebola epidemic on record.⁴ The one hopeful line runs through Uganda, where the linked cluster has gone quiet — the last case was 21 June, and the country is now counting down the 42 days that would let it declare the outbreak over. "The outbreak remains ahead of us," the WHO cautions on the Congolese side. The caveat flagged in No. 46 holds: no vaccine is approved for this species specifically.

1,031

CONFIRMED DEATHS IN CONGO'S BUNDIBUGYO-STRAIN EBOLA OUTBREAK — 2,473 CASES, STILL THE FASTEST-SPREADING ON RECORD, AS UGANDA'S LINKED CLUSTER COUNTS DOWN TO ALL-CLEAR.

A nuclear pact, a command reshuffle, a tariff and a truce offer — the week's diplomacy ran on, indifferent to the fires it was written beside.

IN BRIEF

Canada: Trump imposed 50% tariffs on most Canadian goods — sparing energy, potash, fish and critical minerals — and PM Mark Carney declined to retaliate, saying only that the two would "deepen and speed up" talks; critics at home called it image over results. The levies bite in about thirty days; the market read is on p15.⁵

Gaza: Hamas elected Khalil al-Hayya its overall leader on 20 July, ending roughly two years without one; his first speech (22 July) demanded a permanent ceasefire, full Israeli withdrawal and faster reconstruction. Analysts read the choice as a hardening, not a softening.⁶

DOHA

AL JAZEERA FRAMING

Al Jazeera casts the campaign as US-and-Israeli aggression and gives the Houthi statement its own weight — a declared "maritime embargo against the criminal Saudi enemy," framed as "an eye for an eye" for the war on Yemen and Gaza alike. The region's civilians and the neighbours who did not start the fight, not the belligerents' leverage, are the frame.⁷

BEIJING

CHINESE FRAMING

Beijing keeps to its line: immediate de-escalation and a return to the June framework, paired with concern for the energy flows on which China's economy leans. State media foregrounds the threat to global trade and shipping; Western analysts read the same statements as banking the war's side-effects — cheaper Iranian crude, a distracted Washington — while paying none of its costs.⁸

SOURCES 1 US DoE via NBC News, "Trump signs US-Saudi nuclear deal...", 23 Jul 2026. 2 NBC News, 23 Jul 2026 (Trump: bars enrichment, tied to Abraham Accords; Markey "caving"); Axios, "Trump's Saudi nuclear deal and enrichment," 23 Jul 2026 (critics on enrichment/oversight). 3 Ukrainska Pravda, 22 Jul 2026 (Khmara acting from 20 Jul; Drapatyi named C-in-C 21 Jul; the 22 Jul meeting). 4 Al Jazeera, "Nearly 1,000 people have died from Ebola in DR Congo," 22 Jul 2026; WHO Disease Outbreak News 2026-DON613 (2,473 cases; ~1,031 deaths; Uganda 42-day countdown). 5 NPR, "Trump imposes 50% tariffs on Canadian goods," 21 Jul 2026 (Carney). 6 Al Jazeera, "Hamas names Khalil al-Hayya as new leader," 20 Jul 2026; al-Hayya address, 22 Jul 2026. 7 Al Jazeera, 20–23 Jul 2026 (Houthi "maritime embargo... eye for an eye"; wording via search extract, verified against AJ headline). 8 Chinese state-media framing via regional coverage, 20–23 Jul 2026.

SINGAPORE • THE ECONOMY

A Younger Cabinet Is Sworn In Beneath a Cooling Wire

Monday's new-look ministry inherits a 5.7% growth headline — and a trade cycle already turning over underneath it, with export growth halving in a month and a central-bank decision due the same day.

The reshuffle announced last issue takes the oath on Monday. PM Wong's promoted first-termers — Jeffrey Siow to full Transport Minister and second Finance Minister, David Neo to full minister — are sworn in on 27 July, and the Ministry of Trade and Industry becomes the Ministry of Energy, Trade and Industry from 1 October.¹ But the more consequential story is the economy the fresher bench walks into. Advance figures put second-quarter GDP at 5.7% year-on-year — genuinely strong, yet decelerating from the first quarter's 6.3%, and flattered by a base effect and a front-loaded rush of semiconductors.²

The tell is in the trade wire. June's non-oil domestic exports rose 20.7% on the year — a good number in isolation, but roughly half May's 38.4% pace, and a clear miss against the 30.2% economists had pencilled in.³ Electronics did all the lifting, up 105.1% on AI-driven demand for chips and disk media; strip them out and non-electronic exports actually fell 2.9%. And landing on the same day as the swearing-in is the Monetary Authority's quarterly policy statement, due 27 July and not yet released as this issue closed — so we flag it as pending rather than pre-judge a call the market leans toward leaving on hold. See p15 for the rate read.

THE NEW TEAM, IN BRIEF

Sworn in Monday: Siow (Transport + 2nd Finance), Neo (full minister), with Shanmugam elevated to Senior Minister and Zaqy Mohamad acting on Muslim Affairs after Faishal's exit (No. 49).⁶

The structural move: energy joins trade and industry in the renamed MEeTI from 1 October, under Gan Kim Yong and Tan See Leng — a recognition that energy security is now an economic axis in its own right, not a subheading.

THE CHATTER

The mood on the ground runs cooler than the headline. HardwareZone's long-running "gloomy economy" thread trades cost-of-living gripes and layoff anecdotes that sit oddly beside a 5.7% print, while the r/singapore reaction to the reshuffle skewed to weariness over the Faishal exit and doubt about promoting first-term MPs so fast — directional sentiment, not a poll.⁴

THE SCEPTIC

Read the 5.7% as a rear-view mirror. It is a base-effect-plus-electronics number, and the NODX miss with non-electronics contracting says the broader trade cycle is already rolling over. Note, too, what a Cabinet refresh conveniently changes the subject from — a second sitting-MP conduct matter in a single term. Watch whether Monday's MAS statement leans dovish precisely because officials can see the H2 softening the GDP headline hides.⁵

20.7%

JUNE EXPORT GROWTH — A GOOD NUMBER THAT HALVED MAY'S 38.4% PACE AND MISSED THE ~30.2% FORECAST, THE TRADE CYCLE TURNING UNDER A 5.7% GDP HEADLINE.

GDP +5.7%

NODX MISS

MAS • MON

STILL ON THE WIRE

Inflation expectations held near 3.0% one-year-ahead in the latest SMU-DBS reading, a firm cost-of-living mood as the oil bid feeds through (p15). **The trains kept their record:** LTA reports no MRT delay over 30 minutes since November 2025, the longest clean run since records began — a quiet win carried forward from No. 50, not re-argued. Full URA/HDB Q2 property data lands ~25 July (p6).

SOURCES 1 Prime Minister's Office, "Changes to Cabinet and Other Appointments," 22 Jul 2026; Mothership reshuffle explainer, 22 Jul 2026 (swearing-in 27 Jul; MEeTI from 1 Oct). 2 MTI, "Singapore's GDP grew by 5.7% in the second quarter of 2026," 14 Jul 2026 (advance; +1.1% q/q; manufacturing +12.2%; decelerating from +6.3% Q1). 3 Enterprise Singapore via Xinhua, 17 Jul 2026 (June NODX +20.7%, vs +38.4% May and ~30.2% consensus; electronics +105.1%, non-electronics -2.9%). 4 forums.hardwarezone.com.sg ("gloomy economy" thread) and r/singapore reshuffle reaction, Jul 2026 (directional community sentiment, not quantified). 5 MAS advance-release calendar (July MPS ~27 Jul, not yet issued at press); Meridian analysis. 6 PMO release, 22 Jul 2026; PMO statement on A/Prof Muhammad Faishal Ibrahim's resignation, 20 Jul 2026.

PROPERTY • THE PRIME LAUNCH MARKET

Turf City Tests Its First Private Condo Tomorrow

Dunearn House books on Saturday from S\$1.475 million, brushing S\$3,000 a square foot — the first private home ever launched on the old racecourse land, and a clean read on whether the school-belt buyer still pays up while the mass market cools.

Saturday's launch is a genuine first. Dunearn House — a 380-unit Frasers Property, CSC Land and Sekisui House development — is the first private condominium to be offered on the former Turf City site in Bukit Timah, and it books on 25 July at prices that plant a flag for the prime, school-belt District 11.¹ Two-bedders start at S\$1.475 million, three-bedders at S\$2.597 million and four-bedders at S\$3.588 million, an indicative average around S\$2,799 psf and touching S\$3,000 at the top. The preview that opened on 10 July drew roughly 5,900 visitors in its first weekend — real interest for a launch pitched squarely at Nanyang, Hwa Chong and the primary schools around them.

What makes Dunearn House a useful gauge is that it sits on the opposite side of the market from where the softness is. This week's fresher signal is the confirmation, resolving No. 50's "pending," that the Frasers-led consortium is the top bidder for the S\$2.13 billion Bayshore Drive site — Singapore's first non-central land sale above S\$2 billion — though the formal URA award still awaits government approval.² The prime and integrated end of the market is bidding with conviction; whether that conviction extends past the school belt is exactly what the mass-market data below now doubts.

READ-THROUGH • FOR AN OWNER

The market has split into two speeds and lost its lower gear. If you own **prime or landed**, the tape is with you — Bayshore and Dunearn underwrite District-11-type pricing. If you hold **outer-ring or an HDB flat**, a second quarter of resale declines says price to today's market, not last year's momentum. The June "156 units sold" trough was mechanical — zero projects launched that month — but it is a convenient cover for genuinely thinner mass-market depth.⁵

~\$2,799

INDICATIVE PSF AT DUNEARN HOUSE, TURF CITY'S FIRST-
EVER PRIVATE CONDO, FROM S\$1.475M — A PRIME-
DISTRICT-11 FLAG PLANTED AS THE MASS MARKET SOFTENS.

THE CHATTER

Property-blog and forum reaction splits on the near-S\$3,000 psf ask: bulls call it a fair first-mover premium for freehold-feel land inside the Nanyang-Hwa Chong catchment; sceptics (newlaunchesreview, mychoicehomez echoes) frame it as a medium-to-long hold on unproven Turf City ground, not a flip — and read Bayshore's wide 36% low-to-high bid spread as split developer conviction rather than uniform bullishness.³

THE SCEPTIC

The bullish headlines — a record Bayshore quantum, a near-S\$3,000 psf Turf City launch — are a prime-and-location story being read as the whole market. Underneath, HDB resale fell 0.3% in Q2, a second straight quarterly drop and the first back-to-back decline in about seven years, and URA's Q2 flash shows private gains carried by landed and Core Central while RCR and OCR non-landed actually printed *negative*.⁴ Softer HDB resale saps the upgrader wallet that feeds outer-ring condos; extrapolating Dunearn to the heartland is the trap.

STILL ON THE SHELF

Lentor Gardens Residences — held at its 18 July result (54%, ~S\$2,350 psf) against a ~99% cumulative Lentor Hills track record; no fresh peg, carried forward not re-argued (No. 50). **Jurong Lake District** — the Town Hall Link white site is now live on the 2H2026 Confirmed List (up to 1,200 homes plus 40,000 sqm of office), tender closing 17 November — the "second CBD" anchor advancing on schedule.⁶

SOURCES 1 99.co, "Dunearn House set to launch from S\$1.475m, first condo in Turf City," Jul 2026; Stacked Homes, "Dunearn House preview," Jul 2026 (books 25 Jul; ~S\$2,799 psf; ~5,900 preview visitors). 2 World Construction Network, "Frasers consortium wins Bayshore Drive," Jul 2026; EdgeProp/Yahoo Finance SG; 99.co (formal URA award subject to government approval). 3 newlaunchesreview / property-forum echoes, Jul 2026 (Dunearn pricing; Bayshore 36% bid spread — directional sentiment). 4 99.co / PropNex URA-HDB Q2 flash, 1 Jul 2026 (HDB resale -0.3%; private +0.5% led by landed +2.6% and CCR, RCR/OCR non-landed negative). 5 99.co, "Developers' new-home sales fall to a 2-year low in June," Jul 2026 (156 units, zero launches). 6 URA media release pr26-53 (JLD Town Hall Link white site; tender closes 17 Nov 2026).

TECHNOLOGY · EXPORT CONTROL

Nvidia's Compliance Net Names Singapore Its Problem

The chipmaker has cut more than half its approved Asian buyers and now sends staff to inspect data centres in person — and the re-export loophole it is hunting runs straight through the island, where a chip-diversion case is already in court.

Export control stopped being a paperwork exercise this fortnight and became a site visit. Following US Bureau of Industry and Security guidance from 31 May — which requires a licence for any sale to a China-headquartered entity, wherever the box physically ships — Nvidia has stood up a compliance whitelist and cut more than half of its previously approved AI-chip buyers across Asia.¹ Staff now physically visit data centres, verify contracts and interview end-users in Singapore, Malaysia and Japan. The target is explicit: the re-export loophole through which advanced silicon reaches China via third countries — and Singapore, a favoured transit point, is squarely in the frame.

The island already has the case that gives the policy its texture. Aperia Group chief executive Alan Wei Zhaolun, 50, pleaded not guilty on 6 July to all eleven charges tied to the alleged misrepresentation of server end-users; a S\$55 million Botanic Gardens bungalow, said to have been bought partly with some S\$38 million in criminal proceeds, was seized under a 1 July disposal order, and three corporate entities were charged — the first corporate charges in these probes.² The linked Megaspeed matter has been tied in reporting to more than US\$2 billion in potential orders, a figure that remains investigation-stage rather than proven. The through-line is clean: what

Washington writes as guidance, Nvidia enforces as a whitelist, and a Singapore courtroom is now testing.

>50%

OF NVIDIA'S PREVIOUSLY APPROVED ASIAN AI-CHIP BUYERS CUT FROM ITS COMPLIANCE WHITELIST — WITH IN-PERSON DATA-CENTRE INSPECTIONS NOW RUNNING IN SINGAPORE, MALAYSIA AND JAPAN.

THE CHATTER

On Hacker News and the trade forums the read is that the H200's much-trumpeted return to China is theatre until volume ships: Beijing cleared three more domestic firms to buy on 14 July, and Nvidia and AMD popped on the news, but a US trade official confirmed only a "very few" have actually moved — "a policy signal and sentiment catalyst, not a revenue event."³

THE SCEPTIC

Enforcement-by-whitelist has a cost the headlines skip. Legitimate Southeast Asian cloud builders now shoulder audits, delays and reputational spillover for a diversion problem a handful of brokers created — and physical inspections do not scale to the shell-company churn they are chasing. The Megaspeed "over-US\$2 billion" figure is unproven; treat the deterrent as real and the numbers as provisional.

BIS GUIDANCE

RE-EXPORT LOOPHOLE

H200 · SIGNAL ONLY

WASHINGTON

THE CONTROL VIEW

From the Commerce Department the whitelist is the system working: put the compliance burden on the one company that makes the chips, and you turn every Asian data centre into a checkpoint without a single new customs officer. The H200 clearances are a pressure valve — enough access to keep Nvidia commercially in China while the real frontier parts stay gated.⁴

SINGAPORE

THE TRANSIT VIEW

From the island the same policy reads as collateral risk. Singapore has staked its AI-hub ambitions on being a trusted, neutral node; a diversion scandal and a very public prosecution are the price of that position, and the government's willingness to seize a bungalow and charge corporates is itself the signal — that it would rather lose a few brokers than its standing as a place the chips can be trusted to stay put.⁵

SOURCES 1 Financial Times via Yahoo, "Nvidia halves Asia buyer list," 14–15 Jul 2026; TechTimes, "Nvidia cuts over half Asian AI-chip buyers as BIS compliance net widens," 15 Jul 2026. 2 Mothership, "Aperia Group CEO Alan Wei charged," 6 Jul 2026; The Edge Singapore / Bloomberg (new charges); OnlineCitizen, "S\$55m GCB seized," 1 Jul 2026 (Megaspeed >US\$2bn figure investigation-stage). 3 Phemex / TradingView, 14 Jul 2026 (three firms cleared; NVDA +4.2%, AMD +3.6%); TheStreet, "Nvidia China H200 license," Jul 2026 ("very few" shipped; US trade official). 4 BIS guidance summary via TechTimes, Jul 2026 (licence for China-HQ entities wherever shipped). 5 Meridian analysis on Singapore's AI-hub positioning; case facts per sources 2.

A FORTNIGHT OF OPEN WEIGHTS — MOST OF IT TOO BIG FOR YOUR DESK

Two weeks brought a landslide of open models and a hard lesson in what "open" now means. Thinking Machines Lab — the outfit founded by former OpenAI chief technologist Mira Murati — shipped its first, *Inkling*, on 15 July: a mixture-of-experts transformer, 975 billion parameters total with 41 billion active, a one-million-token context, pretrained on 45 trillion multimodal tokens and released under a genuinely permissive Apache 2.0 licence.¹ The reality check is the file size. Full precision needs roughly two terabytes of VRAM; even Unsloth's aggressive one-bit quantisation lands near 270 gigabytes — past a single RTX Pro 6000 (96GB) or a DGX Spark (128GB). This is a multi-box model, not a daily driver.

WHAT A PROSUMER CAN ACTUALLY SELF-HOST

The useful news sits a tier down. **GLM-5.2** is the community's current best *practical* open coder — 82.7% on Terminal-Bench 2.1, 91.2% GPQA, MIT-licensed — and runs quantised on one 96GB card.² For a local voice or assistant brain, **Qwen3 30B-A3B** is the sweet spot, an Unsloth quant clocking about 45 tokens a second on a single card. The rule of thumb for the reader's rig: a 96GB card holds a ~120B-parameter MoE at Q4 in 60–72GB, or a 70B dense model at Q8 with headroom — near-full-precision quality without leaving the desk.

"Open" now splits in two: open-if-you-own-a-cluster, and the quietly excellent mid-size models that actually fit one card.

~270GB

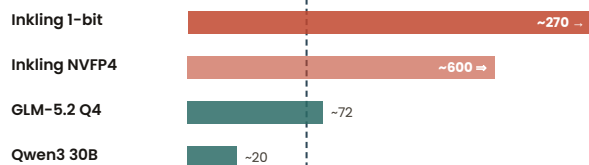
THE SMALLEST ONE-BIT QUANT OF THINKING MACHINES' 975B-PARAMETER INKLING — STILL PAST A SINGLE 96GB CARD. OPEN WEIGHTS, CLOSED TO THE HOME RIG.

THE BANDWIDTH TRAP NOBODY PRICES IN

The reader eyeing a 128GB DGX Spark to hold these big sparse models should read the fine print: capacity is not speed. The Spark's 273 GB/s of memory bandwidth is half an M5 Max's and a fraction of a discrete card's, and one measured run put it near three tokens a second on a dense 70B model.³ It is a fine box for parking a large

model you query occasionally, and a poor one for single-stream dense inference. Match the tool to the model, not to the spec-sheet headline.

FITS ON ONE 96GB CARD? (approx VRAM, GB)



Meridian original - quant sizes approximate 96GB and the line don't fit one card

The fortnight's giants overshoot a single card even at one-bit; the deployable models sit well under it.

THE CHATTER

On r/LocalLLaMA and Hacker News the flood of Apache- and MIT-licensed weights is cheered, with two recurring gripes: the headline giants (Inkling, Kimi K3) are not on OpenRouter yet, so real testing is hard, and "runs on a workstation" is marketing when the accessible quant is still 270GB. GLM-5.2 draws the most *earned* praise as the one people actually deploy.⁴

THE SCEPTIC

Not every number this fortnight was shown. Alibaba previewed **Qwen3.8-Max** at WAIC on 19 July, claiming 2.4 trillion parameters and a spot "second only to Fable 5" — with no benchmark table, no model card, no licence and no weights date. A ranking asserted is not a ranking earned; treat it as vapour until the numbers appear. (The viral rumour that DeepSeek secretly proxies a closed model is likewise unproven.)⁵

IN BRIEF · WATCH THE CLOCK

DeepSeek's legacy API dies today. The *deepseek-chat* and *deepseek-reasoner* names stop resolving at 15:59 UTC on 24 July; migrate agents and Home-Assistant hooks to *deepseek-v4-flash* or *-v4-pro* — a one-line model-field change, same base URL and key.⁶

Kimi K3's weights drop Monday. Moonshot's 2.8-trillion-parameter model — the first 3T-class open release, already top of the Frontend Code Arena — opens on 27 July; a next-issue item, and another cluster-scale download, not a desk one.

The DeepSeek-proxy rumour is false. No evidence supports the viral claim that V4 quietly routes to a closed model — a reminder to check the changelog, not the timeline.

SOURCES 1 Thinking Machines, "Introducing Inkling," 15 Jul 2026; Simon Willison, "Inkling," 16 Jul 2026; Unsloth model docs (975B/41B, Apache 2.0; ~2TB BF16, ~270GB 1-bit). 2 digitalapplied open-weight tracker, Jul 2026 (GLM-5.2: 82.7% Terminal-Bench 2.1, GPQA 91.2%, MIT); localllm.in (Qwen3 30B-A3B ~45 tok/s). 3 hardware-corner / LMSYS DGX Spark benchmarks, Jul 2026 (273 GB/s; ~3 tok/s Llama-70B). 4 r/LocalLLaMA and Hacker News discussion, Jul 2026 (chatter characterised from community context). 5 TechTimes / MarkTechPost, 19–21 Jul 2026 (Qwen3.8-Max preview, no card/benchmarks); Hugging Face blog (DeepSeek-proxy rumour unproven). 6 DEV / Developers Digest DeepSeek V4 migration guides, Jul 2026 (cutover 15:59 UTC 24 Jul).

THE KIT • CINEMA LINE

Sony Slots a New Sensor Between the FX3 and the FX6

The FX5, announced Wednesday, brings a freshly-developed full-frame sensor, internal RAW and — a first for the Cinema Line — Open Gate recording, at a price that lands squarely between Sony's hybrid and its documentary workhorse.

Sony's most interesting camera of the summer is not for photographers at all. Announced on 22 July, the FX5 is a Cinema Line body built around a newly-developed 16.6-megapixel full-frame stacked sensor paired with the BIONZ XR2 processor and a dedicated AI unit, rated at more than fifteen stops of dynamic range with a triple base ISO.¹ Two features matter most to the reader who shoots: it is the first FX-series camera to record **Open Gate** — the full sensor area, so a single take reframes to vertical, square or wide in the edit — and the first to write **internal X-OCN RAW**, up to 5K/60, 4K/120 and Full-HD/240, without an external recorder hanging off the rig.

The positioning is the shrewd part. At US\$4,899 for the body — or US\$5,499 with the XLR handle — the FX5 sits deliberately between the compact FX3 and the documentary-standard FX6, and undercuts the wall a serious hobbyist hits when a hybrid stills camera stops being enough for real video work. Pre-orders opened on announcement and it ships in August. For a reader who has watched the Cinema Line from the outside as an FX3-versus-full-rig dilemma, the FX5 is the machine that dissolves the choice.

DON'T UPGRADE FOR THIS

Oura Ring 5's blood-pressure trick is a software story.

The headline "Health Radar" feature — inferring cardiovascular strain from overnight PPG over rolling 30-day windows — rolls out to **Ring 3 and newer too**, not just the US\$399 Ring 5.³ It does not measure blood pressure like a cuff, and it is not a reason to trade in a working ring. The smaller Ring 5 hardware is the upgrade; the BP feature is not.

THE CHATTER

On the filmmaking forums and r/SonyAlpha the excitement is specifically about Open Gate and internal RAW arriving below the FX6 — "the FX3 successor people actually asked for" — tempered by the usual Cinema Line grumble that 16.6MP is a video-first resolution, so it is no stills replacement, and that rolling shutter and overheating will decide it once units ship.²

THE SCEPTIC

Wait for the tests before the pre-order. Every advance number here — the fifteen-plus stops, the 5K/60 internal RAW — is Sony's own, and the Cinema Line's history is that thermal limits and rolling-shutter behaviour under real load, not the spec sheet, decide whether a body earns its place on a shoot. A "newly-developed sensor" is also a first-generation sensor. Promising; unproven until independent labs weigh in.

\$4,899

BODY-ONLY FOR THE SONY FX5 — FIRST CINEMA LINE CAMERA WITH OPEN GATE AND INTERNAL X-OCN RAW, SLOTTED BETWEEN THE FX3 AND THE FX6.

OPEN GATE

INTERNAL RAW

SHIPS AUGUST

ALSO ON THE BENCH

Meta's next Ray-Bans clear the FCC. EssilorLuxottica filed two new smart-glasses models — "Scriber" and "Blazer" — as production units, a reliable sign a launch is near; separately, a mandatory update now disables the camera if the capture-indicator LED is tampered with, a genuine privacy hardening.⁴ Treat an FCC filing as intent, not a shipping product. **Premium audio** had no new-peg launch in the window — the Sennheiser Momentum 5 and Sony WF-1000XM6 hold as the picks, carried, not re-argued.

SOURCES 1 Sony EU press centre, "Sony launches the FX5," 22 Jul 2026; TechTimes, "Sony FX5 debuts Wednesday: triple ISO, 5K, Open Gate," 19–22 Jul 2026 (16.6MP stacked, BIONZ XR2 + AI, 15+ stops, internal X-OCN RAW; US\$4,899 body / \$5,499 with XLR handle; ships August). 2 r/SonyAlpha and filmmaking-forum reaction, Jul 2026 (chatter characterised from coverage). 3 MacRumors, "Oura Ring 5 unveiled," 28 May 2026; Trusted Reviews, "Don't buy an Oura Ring 5 for blood pressure — it's coming to older rings too," Jul 2026. 4 Road to VR (Meta Scriber/Blazer FCC filings); T3, "Ray-Ban Meta update: no privacy light, no camera," Jul 2026 (FCC filing ≠ confirmed product).

THE CONNECTED HOME · HOME ASSISTANT

Home Assistant Learns to Take Instructions in Plain English

The 2026.7 release lets you build an automation from what you want — "motion detected outside," "bedroom too cold" — and point it at a room instead of an entity ID. For a household migrating off Lutron, it is the feature that finally lowers the cost of moving.

The most useful smart-home update of the month is a quiet one about grammar. Home Assistant 2026.7, released on 1 July, graduates purpose-specific triggers and conditions from its experimental Labs into the default editor: instead of wiring an automation to a named sensor, you describe the intent — "motion detected outside," "temperature too low in the bedroom" — and choose an *area*, and Home Assistant watches every matching sensor in that space for you.¹ The same release added a dedicated IR/RF settings section, in-app Raspberry Pi firmware updates, Dropbox backups and a faster template engine.

For the reader mid-migration from Lutron, this is the release that matters, because the single biggest cost of leaving a proprietary system is re-authoring every scene. Two clean paths exist. The community **Lutron Caseta Pro** integration talks to a Caséta Smart Bridge PRO or RA2 Select over Telnet, exposing dimmers, switches, shades and Pico remotes to Home Assistant directly; and for a Ubiquiti household, a Lutron processor on the same network is auto-discovered and adopted into UniFi Connect, a useful bridge to run both worlds during the switch.² The plain-

English editor is what turns that migration from a weekend of YAML into an afternoon of describing what each room should do. On Matter, the reader's standing position holds: the release's server rewrite is real but not the point here.

THE CHATTER

On [r/homeassistant](#) and the enthusiast blogs the intent-based editor is broadly cheered as "finally fixing one of Home Assistant's biggest flaws" — the gap between knowing what you want and knowing which entity to name. The migrator's thread is practical: pair the new editor with the Caséta bridge and move scenes a room at a time rather than all at once.³

THE SCEPTIC

The abstraction cuts both ways. "Pick an area and let Home Assistant figure it out" hides *which* sensor actually fired, and power users warn that area-based triggers can misfire in dense multi-sensor rooms and are harder to debug than an explicit entity. For a Lutron migrant who wants deterministic, predictable lighting above all, the old entity-level automations may still be the safer build — convenience bought with a little diagnostic blindness.

INTENT-BASED

LUTRON → HA

LOCAL-FIRST

THE LOCAL VOICE BRAIN

A fully-local Assist stack is now a real Alexa replacement: Whisper for speech-to-text over Wyoming, Home Assistant Assist, and a small model — the Qwen3 family is the community's pick — served from Ollama, with 2–4 second responses on a GPU.⁴ Note the moving part: Piper was archived in late 2025, so Home Assistant now offers a faster "Speech-to-Phrase" path. The reader's RTX Pro 6000 (p8) can host the whole voice brain locally — no cloud in the loop.

STILL ON THE SHELF

UniFi Access landed as a native Home Assistant integration back in 2026.4 — worth knowing for a Ubiquiti household consolidating door control into the same dashboard.⁵ **Next release:** Home Assistant 2026.8 is due around 5 August; no need to chase the beta. Carried, not re-argued: the migration is a project measured in rooms, not a single switch-over.

SOURCES 1 [home-assistant.io](#) blog, "2026.7," 1 Jul 2026; TechTimes, "Home Assistant 2026.7 arrives July 1: intent-based automations," 29 Jun 2026 (intent triggers, area targeting, IR/RF section, Dropbox backup, Pi firmware). 2 GitHub, [upsert/lutron-caseta-pro](#) (Caséta Smart Bridge PRO / RA2 Select over Telnet); Ubiquiti Help, "Integrating Lutron processors with UniFi Connect." 3 [r/homeassistant](#) and enthusiast coverage (Maison & Domotique), Jul 2026 (chatter characterised from coverage; no single thread cited). 4 Botmonster / Kunal Ganglani local-voice guides, 2026 (Whisper + Wyoming + Assist + Ollama; Qwen3; Piper archived Oct 2025 → Speech-to-Phrase). 5 [home-assistant.io](#), UniFi Access integration (added 2026.4).

THE GOOD LIFE · THE AUCTION ROOM

The Strongest Watch Half in History Just Closed

Phillips sold more watches in six months than any house had ever managed in a full year — and a 99.8% sell-through with 40% first-time buyers looks, depending where you stand, like a market in rude health or one running hot.

The auction houses reported their half-year in mid-July and the watch numbers are the story. Phillips, in association with Bacs & Russo, sold US\$235.5 million of watches in the first six months of 2026 — more, the house notes, than it had ever achieved across a full year — inside a total of US\$507 million, up roughly 60% on the equivalent 2025 season.¹ Its Geneva sale became, by its own accounting, the most successful watch auction in history: across 937 lots the sell-through rate was 99.8% — two lots unsold — with average lot values up about 55% and first-time buyers making up some 40% of purchasers. Christie's and Sotheby's echoed the pattern, their luxury and watch categories driving a broad rebound after two softer years.²

For the reader who buys the odd serious watch, the read-through is double-edged. A market this liquid means a good piece sells, and sells well — reassuring if you own. But a 99.8% clearance with average prices up more than half in a year, and two in five buyers brand new to the room, is the kind of print that makes seasoned dealers reach for the word "froth." The strength is concentrated in trophy references, not spread evenly across the market, which is a very different thing from every watch being worth more.

THE HEADPHONE CYCLE REFRESHES

No single new-peg launch this fortnight, but the flagship trio worth a reader's attention has settled: **Sennheiser Momentum 5 Wireless** (~US\$399, aptX Lossless, replaceable battery) is the value pick; **Focal Bathys MG** (~US\$1,499, magnesium drivers, USB-DAC mode) the aspirational one; **Sony's 1000X "ColleXion"** marks the line's tenth year at ~US\$649.⁵ Carried as the current state of play, not a fresh peg — hold for a real launch.

99.8%

SELL-THROUGH AT PHILLIPS GENEVA — 935 OF 937 LOTS — WITH AVERAGE LOT VALUES UP ~55% AND FIRST-TIME BUYERS ~40% OF THE ROOM. THE BEST WATCH HALF EVER RECORDED.

THE CHATTER

On the collector forums and WatchCrunch the mood is part vindication, part vertigo: the market many declared dead in 2024 has come roaring back, but the same threads note the gains are stacked in a handful of hyped references — independents, steel Pateks, the odd Rolex — while mid-tier lots move at sensible money. "A rising tide for the trophies, not the fleet," as one put it.³

THE SCEPTIC

Read the record with one eyebrow raised. Art & Object notes that watches and jewellery are now *cannibalising* fine-art sales rather than adding to a growing whole — a rotation of the same luxury money, not new demand — and a 55% jump in average lot value with 40% first-time buyers reads to sceptics as speculation concentrated in trophy references, the classic late-cycle tell.⁴ Health and froth can print the same number; only the next down-cycle tells them apart.

PHILLIPS

99.8% SOLD

TROPHY BID

THE WEAK-YEN ESCAPE

The soft yen (p15) keeps Japan a value play even at the top of the market, and the 2026 luxury-hotel pipeline has caught up: **1 Hotel Tokyo** (a biophilic 1,500-plant build with sound baths) and the **Waldorf Astoria Osaka** anchor a wave pushing beyond the Tokyo-Kyoto-Osaka triangle.⁶ A note for the autumn trip the Diary is building (p20): the FX read that flatters the shopping flatters the suites too.

SOURCES 1 ArtNews, "Phillips spring 2026 auction sales \$507 million," 10 Jul 2026; Robb Report; The Art Newspaper, "Phillips leans on luxury watches," 10 Jul 2026 (\$235.5m watches; 937 lots, 99.8% sell-through; avg lot +55%; ~40% first-time buyers). 2 The Art Newspaper, "Trophy lots and luxury goods fuel rebound for Christie's and Sotheby's," 15 Jul 2026. 3 Collector-forum / WatchCrunch sentiment, Jul 2026 (characterised from coverage). 4 Art & Object, "Luxury watch and jewelry business threatening art sales," Jul 2026. 5 What Hi-Fi?; Gear Patrol hi-fi roundup; ecoustics, Jul 2026 (Momentum 5, Focal Bathys MG, Sony ColleXion). 6 Forbes Travel Guide, 14 May 2026 (1 Hotel Tokyo); Hospitality Design, 2026 Japan hotel pipeline (Waldorf Astoria Osaka).

SCREEN & SOUND · BOX OFFICE

Spider-Man Aims to Prove the Summer Was No Fluke

A week after Nolan's *Odyssey* filled cinemas with a three-hour Greek epic, *Brand New Day* opens on 31 July with presales the industry hasn't seen in years — the second test in a fortnight of whether the theatre is genuinely back.

The cinema's best summer in years faces its next exam on Friday. *Spider-Man: Brand New Day* — Tom Holland and Zendaya, directed by Destin Daniel Cretton — opens 31 July on a wave of record advance sales, with trade trackers running hot: Deadline has it opening north of US\$180 million domestically, while Box Office Pro's long-range forecast reaches US\$230–250 million.¹ Those are projections, not receipts, and worth holding as such — but the presale signal is real, and it lands directly on top of the summer's other proof point.

That proof point is still in cinemas. Christopher Nolan's *The Odyssey* opened the prior weekend to US\$124.5 million domestic and US\$264.1 million worldwide — his biggest launch since *The Dark Knight Rises* — with premium large-format screens delivering roughly 53% of the domestic gross and IMAX alone about US\$51.8 million, against 95% on Rotten Tomatoes and an "A" CinemaScore.² A three-

hour, format-obsessive Homer adaptation and a tentpole *Spider-Man* in successive weekends is the closest thing 2026 has offered to an argument that the theatrical event has a pulse again — one for the prestige crowd, one for everyone.

~53%

OF *THE ODYSSEY*'S DOMESTIC GROSS CAME FROM PREMIUM LARGE-FORMAT SCREENS — IMAX ALONE ~US\$51.8M — THE FORMAT DOING REAL BOX-OFFICE WORK, NOT JUST MARKETING.

THE CHATTER

On r/movies and the box-office forums the *Odyssey* discourse was about access as much as art — cinephiles queuing for 2am and 7am 70mm screenings, tickets to the handful of true IMAX-film houses reselling at a premium — while the *Spider-Man* threads argue whether Cretton's grounded reboot can hold the older audience Nolan just proved still shows up.³

31 JULY

PRESALE RECORD

THEATRE'S BACK?

ON THE TURNTABLE

A stacked mid-July release date has settled into the summer's soundtrack: verified 17 July drops include **Kasabian's *Act III***, **Motionless in White's *Decades*** and **DJ Khaled's *Aalam of God***.⁴ A word of caution on the rumour mill: widely-shared "July drops" for Madonna, the Rolling Stones, Ariana Grande and Olivia Rodrigo remain unconfirmed by their labels — treat them as speculation, not a release calendar.

FOR THE CULTURE TRAVELLER

Busan International Film Festival (Asia's largest, running into October) pairs naturally with the autumn-foliage swing the Diary is mapping (p20) — a Korea-then-Japan cultural itinerary for a reader who plans trips around what is worth seeing on a screen as much as what is worth eating.

THE SCEPTIC

Keep the *Spider-Man* numbers in their box: they are pre-release tracking, and tracking has a long history of running hot into a big opening and then quietly resetting once the actuals land. Presales measure the die-hards who were always going on opening night, not the casual audience that decides a film's legs in week two. The genuinely proven data point this fortnight is *The Odyssey*'s receipts; the *Spider-Man* figure is a forecast wearing a headline's clothes.

SOURCES 1 Deadline, "Spider-Man: Brand New Day box office opening projection," Jul 2026 (\$180m+); Box Office Pro long-range forecast, Jul 2026 (\$230–250m) — pre-release projections, not results. 2 Variety; CNBC; IndieWire (IMAX 70mm ~\$51.8m, ~53% PLF); Hollywood Reporter, 19 Jul 2026 (*The Odyssey* \$124.5m domestic / \$264.1m worldwide; 95% RT; "A" CinemaScore). 3 r/movies and box-office-forum discussion, Jul 2026 (characterised from coverage). 4 Official Charts new-albums-2026; AlbumOfTheYear, 17 Jul 2026 (Kasabian, Motionless in White, DJ Khaled; Madonna/Stones/Grande/Rodrigo July drops unconfirmed).

THE FAMILY DESK · THE EVIDENCE

It Was Never the Hours. It's the Relationship to the Screen

The best study yet built on children the age of an eleven-year-old finds that problematic use — the compulsion, not the clock — is what predicts trouble. It points a worried parent at a far more useful thing to watch.

The most decision-useful screen research of the year is not another hours-versus-harm scare. A UCSF team led by Jason Nagata, publishing in the *American Journal of Preventive Medicine*, followed 8,119 children who reported their screen use at exactly ages eleven to twelve and tracked them a year forward.¹ The finding reframes the whole debate: it was not the raw number of hours that predicted higher depressive symptoms, suicidal behaviours, disturbed sleep and earlier substance-use initiation — it was *problematic* use, the compulsive, can't-stop pattern across social media, games and phones. Two children can log the same three hours; the one who melts down when the screen is removed is the one the data worries about.

That flips a parent's job from counting minutes to reading a relationship. The July delta sharpening the point comes from the Family Online Safety Institute, whose 9 July survey of some 4,000 parents and children found kids consistently report more digital life than parents realise: 38% of children said they had used generative AI in the past week against 27% of parents' estimates — an eleven-point blind spot, repeated across social media and posting.² The lesson is not to panic about the gap but to close it by asking, because the thing worth watching —

compulsion — is invisible from the outside unless you are actually talking to your child about what she does on the screen.

Two kids can log the same three hours. The one who can't stop is the one the evidence is actually about.

8,119

CHILDREN TRACKED FROM AGES 11–12, WHERE PROBLEMATIC SCREEN USE — NOT TOTAL HOURS — PROSPECTIVELY PREDICTED DEPRESSION, POOR SLEEP AND EARLIER SUBSTANCE USE (NAGATA ET AL., AJPM).

THE CHATTER

On r/ScienceBasedParenting the practical consensus is unusually settled: watch for the tells of compulsion — distress when the device is taken, sneaking it, lost sleep — rather than policing a nightly hour count, and delay the algorithmic social feed while a call-and-text phone covers reachability. The recurring reminder is that a child models the phone habits she sees in the adult more than the ones she is told.³

PROBLEMATIC USE

NOT THE CLOCK

AGES 11–12

THE JULY DELTAS

The AI-companion turn: a *JAMA Pediatrics* study found the share of US adolescents using AI chatbots for mental-health advice rose from about one in eight to one in five in a year — a fast-moving reason to ask what your daughter turns to when she's low.⁴

The settings don't save you: a Northeastern audit of 86 child-safety features across the big platforms found only about 40% worked as advertised. Don't outsource the job to in-app toggles.

WHAT TO ACTUALLY DO

The playbook for an eleven-year-old is duller than the headlines: **watch the relationship, not the clock** — compulsion is the signal. **Delay the social feed, not the phone. Protect sleep and movement** (the levers on p14). And **talk, so the FOSI gap closes**. Singapore's "Screen Smart from the Start" portal puts an eleven-year-old in the 7–12 band and favours co-viewing over a ban. General guidance, not medical advice.⁵

SOURCES 1 *American Journal of Preventive Medicine*, Nagata et al. (UCSF, ABCD Study), online 11 Feb 2026 — prospective, n=8,119 children reporting screen use at ages 11–12; problematic use (not total hours) predicted depressive symptoms, suicidal behaviours, sleep disturbance, earlier substance use. 2 Family Online Safety Institute / Ipsos, 9 Jul 2026 (~4,000 US & Australia parents+children; GenAI 38% kids vs 27% parents). 3 r/ScienceBasedParenting discussion, Jul 2026 (characterised from community context). 4 *JAMA Pediatrics*, McBain et al. (RAND/Harvard/MIT/Brown), online 1 Jun 2026 (~1 in 8 → ~1 in 5); Northeastern University child-safety-features audit, 29 Jun 2026 (35 of 86 worked as advertised). 5 MDDI, "Screen Smart from the Start," bescreensmart.gov.sg (7–12 age band). General guidance, not medical advice.

THE AGE-GATE ERA ARRIVES AT THE APP STORE

The policy world is moving faster than the evidence, and a parent should track both. On 6 July the US Supreme Court let Texas's App Store Accountability Act take effect: app-store accounts for under-eighteens must link to a parent or guardian, with verified parental consent required for downloads and purchases, while the merits fight moves to the Fifth Circuit.¹ It follows Australia's under-sixteen social-media ban, live since December — now being *strengthened* after weak compliance, with more than five million child accounts deactivated even as a University of Newcastle study found over 85% of under-sixteens still used social media in the three months after. The lesson for a Singapore household is sober: bans and gates leak, so the work still lands at home.

~0.4%

OF THE VARIANCE IN ADOLESCENT WELL-BEING EXPLAINED BY DIGITAL-TECH USE, ACROSS ~355,000 PARTICIPANTS — ABOUT THE SAME AS WEARING GLASSES (PRZYBYLSKI ET AL.).

KEEP THE PANIC PROPORTIONAL

The single most useful corrective to the doom headlines is a number. Andrew Przybylski and colleagues, pooling data on roughly 355,000 young people, found digital-technology use explains at most about 0.4% of the variance in adolescent well-being — comparable to wearing spectacles.² Candice Odgers of UC Irvine puts the gap plainly: there is "a massive gap between the story parents are told about screens, and what all of the evidence actually tells us," and warns that wildly different activities get "collapsed into a single moral-panic category." Her steer is the one to keep: ask first whether your daughter has friends, activities she loves and a connected family, before fixating on the tablet.

None of that means "do nothing." It means spend the worry where the evidence is — on compulsion and on sleep — rather than on a raw hour count. The recurring finding across 2026's youth literature is that much of the apparent "screen" harm runs through lost sleep and displaced movement, both of which a consistent bedtime and a phone that charges outside the bedroom largely fix.³

Bans and gates leak — over 85% of Australia's under-16s still used social media after the ban. The work still lands at home.

DON'T BE ALARMIST

The scariest single numbers in this field come from surveys that cannot separate cause from effect: an anxious child may reach for a screen as much as a screen makes her anxious. The defensible stance for a parent of an eleven-year-old is neither panic nor permissiveness — hold the boring fundamentals (sleep, movement, delayed social feeds, honest conversation), and treat frightening headline figures as prompts to check in, not verdicts to act on in fear.

THE ONE DISTINCTION WORTH DRAWING

If a household takes one idea from the fortnight's research, make it the split between the *device* and the *feed*. A phone that calls, texts and maps is a tool an eleven-year-old can carry safely; an account on an engagement-optimised social platform is a different object with a different incentive, and the evidence that troubles researchers clusters around the second, not the first. The whole age-gate fight is really about the moment the two get bundled together at handover — which is exactly the moment a parent has the most leverage to keep them apart.

THE CHATTER

The r/ScienceBasedParenting consensus is unusually practical: a call-and-text device or a locked-down phone through the tween years, social platforms delayed to the mid-teens, and — the part parents resist — the same rules applied to the adult in the house. On the new AI-companion worry (p13), the steer is to make the household model, not a chatbot, the first place a low mood gets taken.⁴

THE SINGAPORE LINE

Singapore has deliberately *not* reached for a ban. The MDDI's "Screen Smart from the Start" movement, launched by PM Wong in May, runs on co-viewing, boundaries and offline time, with age-banded guidance that puts an eleven-year-old in the 7-12 tier.⁵ The bet is that a talking, modelling household beats a legislated gate — and the leaky overseas bans this fortnight are, quietly, evidence for it.

SOURCES 1 SCOTUSblog, "Supreme Court allows Texas to enforce app-store age-verification and parental-consent law," 6 Jul 2026; Fortune, "Australia enforcement of under-16 social-media ban," Jun 2026 (5m+ accounts deactivated; Univ. of Newcastle 85%+ still using). 2 Przybylski et al., analysis across ~355,000 participants (digital use ~0.4% of well-being variance); C. Odgers (UC Irvine), "Stop the freakout over kids' screen time," developingadolescent.semel.ucla.edu. 3 *Frontiers in Pediatrics*, Du et al., 22 Jul 2026 (sleep as the mediating lever; recurring 2026 finding). 4 r/ScienceBasedParenting discussion, Jul 2026 (characterised from community context). 5 MDDI, "Screen Smart from the Start," bescreensmart.gov.sg (7-12 age band). General guidance, not medical advice.

THE MACRO DESK

Oil over \$100 flips the Fed's question from cut to hike

A supply shock is an inflation shock: yields ran to year highs, the dollar firmed, equities sold off and gold caught a haven bid — with the July meeting and the MAS statement both landing next week. Market explanation and education, not investment advice; forecasts flagged as forecasts.

VWRA ~\$187.8 ▼	GLOBAL BONDS (BNDW) ~4.6% yield ▼	US 10Y 4.66% ▲	DXY ~100.9 ▲	USD/SGD 1.2917	BRENT >\$100 ▲	GOLD ~\$4,050 ▲	BTC ~\$65,000 ▼
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Start with the barrel, because the week broke on it. With three tankers hit and both straits live (p3), Brent pushed past US\$100 intraday on 23 July — its first three-figure print since spring — and West Texas followed to about US\$90.¹ A supply shock in oil is an inflation shock everywhere else, and that single fact reorganised every other market. The regime has a name: risk-off, dollar-bid, and a higher-for-longer stance tipping toward the once-unthinkable — a rate rise.

That is the pivot. Rate-cut pricing has evaporated. Into the 28–29 July FOMC, CME FedWatch still leans to a hold (~83% as of 21 July), but the market now prices roughly a 61% chance of a hike by September.² Singapore's own call lands the same Monday: the MAS statement was not yet out as this issue closed, so we flag it pending. Treat every point estimate as a forecast.

A supply shock in oil is an inflation shock everywhere else — and it has turned the Fed's live question from when to cut into whether to hike.

The mechanics ran straight down the board. The 10-year yield pushed to about 4.66%, a year high, and the dollar firmed near 100.9 on the higher-for-longer read; the yen stayed weak (USD/JPY near 165), while USD/SGD printed 1.2917 — a firm Singapore dollar that still flatters the autumn-Japan arithmetic on p20.³ The fresh 50% US tariff on Canada (p4) is one more upside-inflation pebble on the scale.

VWRA — the reader's core — gave ground with global equities, which sold off on the double blow of \$100 oil

and heavy AI-capex prints: the S&P 500 fell about 1.2% and the Nasdaq 2.1% on 23 July, dragged by Alphabet (–7%) and Tesla (–14%).⁴ After a record near 7,509 on 21 July, this is a pullback, not a crash. **Global bonds** are the pressured leg — yields near 4.6% mean price headwinds now, forward yield later.

Gold did its job, catching a haven-and-inflation bid to around US\$4,050 (US\$4,150 intraday) — but frame it as a bid, not a record: January's all-time high near US\$5,602 is still well above.⁵ **Bitcoin** is the tell — soft near US\$65,000 (a single-source print, held lightly), trading as a capped risk asset rather than "digital gold," with little of gold's ballast as hikes return.⁶

WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

A higher-for-longer regime with an oil shock bolted on and a Fed that has stopped talking about cuts. VWRA's pullback is orderly, not a break — the visible risk is the 29th; global bonds earn price pain now and yield later; gold is doing its hedge job, but as a bid off its January record, not a new peak. Bitcoin is the most liquidity-sensitive of the four, read here for sensitivity, not endorsed. None of this is advice to buy, sell or hold; the reader's anchors remain VWRA and global bonds.

THE SCEPTIC

Two contrarian trades sit against the panic. The **stagflation bears** (Gary Shilling calls a 2026 downturn "almost inevitable") say the oil bid tips a soft economy over. The subtler, opposite take: the Boston Fed's own work argues the US is less vulnerable to oil shocks than the 1970s implies, and the real error may be central banks *over-tightening* into the shock — "policy-mistake territory." The priced hikes, not the oil, could be the mistake.⁷

RISK-OFF

HIKE RISK

DOLLAR BID

SOURCES 1 CNBC oil report, 23 Jul 2026 (Brent >\$100 intraday, first since spring; WTI ~\$90). 2 CME FedWatch (~83% hold into 28–29 Jul FOMC; ~61% hike priced by Sept, 21 Jul); TradingEconomics, 23 Jul; MAS advance-release calendar (July MPS ~27 Jul, not yet issued at press). 3 TradingEconomics (US 10Y ~4.66%, year high); Capital.com (DXY ~100.9); MTFX (USD/JPY ~165); Bloomberg (USD/SGD 1.2917, 23 Jul). 4 CNBC / Motley Fool, 23 Jul 2026 (S&P 500 7,408, –1.21%; Nasdaq ~2.15%; Alphabet –7%, Tesla –14%; record ~7,509 on 21 Jul). 5 Fortune / TradingEconomics, 23 Jul (gold ~\$4,050 spot, ~\$4,150 intraday; record ~\$5,602 on 29 Jan 2026). 6 CoinGabbbar, 23 Jul (BTC ~\$65k — single source, held lightly). 7 Investing.com (Shilling; recession odds); Boston Fed, "Reassessing the US economy's vulnerability to oil shocks," 2026 (over-tightening risk). Market explanation, not investment advice.

CURIOSITIES • ASTRONOMY

The Comet We've Been Tracking Is Older Than the Sun

Before it leaves for good, the interstellar visitor we first flagged in No. 49 gave up its age. New spectroscopy reads it as a fragment of a star system that formed — and likely died — billions of years before ours existed.

The parting gift is the best part. Astronomers using the Very Large Telescope have measured the chemistry of interstellar comet 3I/ATLAS — the third such object ever found, which this desk has followed out since No. 49 — and the fingerprint is startling: heavy-hydrogen (deuterium) enrichment and unusually high carbon-and-nitrogen isotope ratios in its cyanide, a signature laid down only in the cold outskirts of an old, low-metallicity star system.¹ The implication is that 3I/ATLAS is likely more than twice the age of the Sun — on the order of seven billion years old. It is, in the most literal sense, a piece of a dead solar system passing through ours, and the oldest comet humanity has ever put a number on.

Hold the retellable line, because it is genuinely one for the dinner table: the oldest comet we have ever measured is a shard of a star system that formed, and probably burned out, before the Sun ignited — and it is now leaving our neighbourhood forever, outbound past Saturn's orbit and on toward Uranus's by 2027. Three of the great instruments of the age — the VLT, Rubin and the Parker Solar Probe, with JWST earlier in the year — all trained on it in its brief passage, a rare case of the whole observational fleet turning to catch one traveller before it was gone.

AN ATMOSPHERE, 49 LIGHT-YEARS AWAY

A team led by the Center for Astrophysics reported in *Science* (17 July) the strongest evidence yet that a rocky planet in its star's habitable zone can hold an atmosphere — the super-Earth LHS 1140 b, via helium escaping to space.³ Read the wording carefully: this is a helium-escape signature consistent with an atmosphere, not a confirmed one, and LHS 1140 b has drawn earlier claims — but it is a real step toward answering whether such worlds keep their air.

A shard of a star system that formed, and probably died, before the Sun ignited — now leaving our neighbourhood forever.

The age matters beyond the trivia. A seven-billion-year-old interstellar comet is a direct sample of galactic chemistry from an era the Sun never witnessed, and its deuterium ratio is a data point on how planet-building ices formed in the early Milky Way — the kind of measurement that, until interstellar visitors started arriving, astronomers could only model.

~7 bn

YEARS — THE LIKELY AGE OF 3I/ATLAS, MORE THAN TWICE THE SUN'S, FROM DEUTERIUM AND ISOTOPE RATIOS READ BY THE VLT. THE OLDEST COMET EVER MEASURED.

THE CHATTER

Across r/space and r/astrophysics the hook that carried it was not the size but the age — "older than the Sun, and we only got weeks with it." The wistful thread is that a once-in-a-generation object arrived, was measured by nearly every major instrument at once, and is already on its way out, never to return.²

3I/ATLAS

OLDER THAN THE SUN

OUTBOUND

THE SCEPTIC

3I/ATLAS, the minority view. Harvard's Avi Loeb still argues the object shows anomalies worth a look; the consensus, now bolstered by the age result, holds it a natural ancient comet.⁴ Apply the same discipline to LHS 1140 b: an escaping-helium signature is evidence consistent with an atmosphere, not a confirmed one. The boring, well-measured reading keeps winning.

SOURCES 1 ESO release eso2608, Jul 2026 (VLT spectroscopy of 3I/ATLAS; deuterium enrichment, high C/N isotope ratios; likely >2× the Sun's age); phys.org; Sky & Telescope, Jul 2026. 2 r/space, r/astrophysics discussion, Jul 2026 (characterised from coverage). 3 *Science*, Center for Astrophysics | Harvard & Smithsonian, 17 Jul 2026 (LHS 1140 b, helium escape — "consistent with an atmosphere," not a confirmed one); Smithsonian Magazine; EarthSky. 4 A. Loeb (Medium), Jul 2026 (minority view); consensus per ESO/NASA 3I/ATLAS material.

LOVE & LIFE · THE DATING RECESSION

The Dating Recession Is Now a Numbers Story

Young adults are dating less, the apps are shrinking, and the cohort that grew up on them is the loneliest with them. For a parent of an eleven-year-old, this is a preview of the romantic world she will inherit — slower, warier, and offline.

The "dating recession" has stopped being a vibe and become a data set. Only about 31% of young adults are actively dating, according to the Institute for Family Studies' *State of Our Unions 2026*, and roughly 74% of young women reported dating little or not at all in the past year.¹ The apps that were supposed to fix all this are themselves in retreat: some 78% of Gen Z report dating-app burnout, and — the finding that ought to give the industry pause — Gen Z is the only cohort that says it feels lonelier with the apps than without them. Cost is part of it, with an average date now put near US\$189, but the deeper shift is a generation opting out of a machine it finds exhausting.

For a mid-40s reader the interesting angle is not one's own dating life but the one taking shape for the next generation. The world an eleven-year-old will enter is being rebuilt now: more in-person, more deliberately "slow," strikingly therapy-literate — a *Millennial Intimacy Report* found 51% prefer to date people who are in therapy, and one in eight actively filter for it — and deeply sceptical of the swipe.² Whatever replaces the app era, today's tweens will inherit its manners, and those manners are being written as a reaction against exactly the machine their parents' generation built.

THE THERAPY FILTER

The most telling single data point is generational: a survey of 2,000 millennials found 51% prefer to date or befriend people in therapy, and 12% actively filter for it on apps.⁴ Emotional literacy has become a stated dating criterion rather than a private matter — a shift with obvious downstream implications for how an eleven-year-old will one day be taught to choose a partner. Directional, self-reported.

~31%

OF YOUNG ADULTS ARE ACTIVELY DATING (IFS, *STATE OF OUR UNIONS 2026*) — WITH ~78% OF GEN Z REPORTING DATING-APP BURNOUT AND THE COHORT LONELIER WITH THE APPS THAN WITHOUT.

THE CHATTER

Across r/dating and the culture press the mood is less despair than fatigue: threads describe deleting the apps for "raw-dogging life," meeting people through hobbies and run clubs, and treating a first date's US\$189 tab as a reason to be choosier, not sadder. The recurring line is that the recession is partly a boycott — a generation refusing a product it finds bad, not a generation that has given up on love.³

THE SCEPTIC

Handle every figure here with tongs. Almost all of it is self-reported survey data, several of the splashiest numbers PR-commissioned by dating companies with an obvious interest in the story, and the "31% actively dating" headline swings hard on how you define "dating." The IFS is an advocacy organisation, and nearly all of it is US data — directional for Singapore, not gospel. The trend is real; the precision is borrowed confidence.

DATING RECESSION

APP FATIGUE

SELF-REPORT

THE EXAMINED-LIFE READ

Set beside last issue's "chatfishing," a pattern emerges: the same generation outsourcing its openers to a chatbot is also the one most exhausted by the apps those chatbots live on. The durable point is not that romance is dying but that it is *re-forming* around scarcity and sincerity — fewer dates, taken more seriously, with the authenticity test moved firmly off the screen.

SOURCES 1 Institute for Family Studies, *State of Our Unions 2026* (~31% actively dating; ~74% of young women dated little/none); Forbes Health (~78% Gen Z dating-app burnout); Newsweek (Gen Z lonelier with apps), 2026 — self-report; IFS is an advocacy org. 2 *The Millennial Intimacy Report* (Dating.com survey, n=2,000), released Dec 2025 (51% prefer partners in therapy; 12% filter for it) — PR-commissioned. 3 r/dating and culture-press discussion, Jul 2026 (characterised from coverage; ~US\$189 average-date figure via Forbes Health). 4 As source 2. Directional US data; general observation, not advice.

FITNESS · THE SCIENCE OF AGEING MUSCLE

A Singapore Lab Finds the Switch Exercise Flips

Duke-NUS researchers identified a gene that rises in ageing muscle and tips its protein balance the wrong way — and found that exercise turns it back down. It is mechanism, not a pill, and that distinction is the whole story.

The most quietly important longevity paper of the month came out of Singapore. Researchers at Duke-NUS Medical School, with Singapore General Hospital and Cardiff, identified a gene called **DEAF1** that rises in ageing muscle and pushes the cell's mTORC1 activity too high, wrecking the delicate balance between building new proteins and clearing damaged ones.¹ The elegant part is what reverses it: exercise suppresses DEAF1, restoring that balance so old muscle can clean house and rebuild. In fruit flies and aged mice, raising DEAF1 weakened muscle and lowering it restored strength — a clean causal chain published in *PNAS*.

For a mid-40s reader the read-through is motivating and, crucially, honest: the *behaviour* — combined resistance and aerobic training — is what pulls DEAF1 and mTORC1 back into line, and no supplement yet replicates it. The temptation with any "molecular switch" finding is to wait for the drug; the actual instruction here is the one already on the gym schedule. Mechanism, not medicine.

DEAF1

THE GENE THAT CLIMBS IN AGEING MUSCLE AND UNBALANCES ITS PROTEIN TURNOVER — AND THAT EXERCISE TURNS BACK DOWN, RESTORING STRENGTH IN AGED MICE (DUKE-NUS, *PNAS*).

THE CHATTER

On r/longevity the rapamycin discourse is the magnet, because it rhymes with the DEAF1 mechanism (both run through mTOR): the year-long PEARL trial — the longest human rapamycin healthspan study yet — missed its primary endpoint, with only scattered secondary signals. The nuanced community read is that rapamycin may help the "inflamed, sedentary" adult more than a lean, well-trained, Oura-optimising one, who likely has less to gain.²

THE SCEPTIC

Three cautions before the headline runs away. DEAF1 is **flies and mice**, not humans — treat "molecular switch" as mechanism, not a dosing plan. The strength-training "sweet spot" below is **observational**, so the dose is a useful target, not proof that hitting it causes the mortality drop. And rapamycin for healthy-person longevity remains **off-label and unproven**, its flagship trial having just missed its main goal. General guidance, not medical advice.

DEAF1

MTOR

DUKE-NUS

THE STRENGTH SWEET SPOT HAS A NUMBER

A pooled analysis of 147,374 adults across three cohorts, tracked up to 30 years (*British Journal of Sports Medicine*), found the optimum is about **90–119 minutes of resistance training a week** — associated with ~13% lower all-cause, ~19% lower cardiovascular and ~27% lower neurological mortality, with no added benefit beyond ~120 minutes and the biggest effect when combined with aerobic work.³ Two gym hours a week, roughly — a target, not a promise.

THE RAPAMYCIN REALITY CHECK

The PEARL trial's miss is the useful corrective to the longevity-supplement hype cycle: the most-watched anti-ageing molecule ran its longest human test and did not hit its primary endpoint.⁴ The pattern holds across this desk — the boring, behavioural levers (train, sleep, protein) keep out-evidencing the exciting pharmacological ones. Watch item, not a recommendation.

SOURCES 1 *PNAS*, Duke-NUS / SGH / Cardiff, "DEAF1 and mTORC1 in ageing muscle," 2026 (release 23 Jun 2026; ScienceDaily) — flies and aged mice; exercise suppresses DEAF1. 2 r/longevity discussion, Jul 2026 (characterised); PEARL trial results via PMC (48 weeks, primary endpoint not met). 3 *British Journal of Sports Medicine*, pooled analysis, Jun 2026 (n=147,374; ~90–119 min/week optimum; ~13% all-cause, ~19% CV, ~27% neurological lower mortality) — observational. 4 PEARL trial (PMC), 2026. General guidance, not medical advice.

THE DIARY

The October Rush Comes Into Focus

The autumn stack has firmed up — a two-night stadium run, Singapore's first F1 Sprint weekend, and three brand-new tables worth a detour. Book the clashes first.

SINGAPORE

DATED & BOOKABLE

- 2-3 OCT

★ **The Weeknd — After Hours Til Dawn, National Stadium**

TWO NIGHTS, THE FINAL LEG OF THE TOUR (NO. 49) · LATE SHOW, NOT A SCHOOL-NIGHT PICK FOR A TWEEN · BOOK THE ROOM BEFORE THE SECOND NIGHT SELLS THE FIRST
- 9-11 OCT

★ **F1 Singapore Airlines Grand Prix — Marina Bay**

SINGAPORE'S FIRST-EVER SPRINT WEEKEND — RACING EVERY DAY · WALKABOUT GA FROM ~\$S198/DAY · BRING EAR PROTECTION FOR CHILDREN · BUY ONLY VIA SINGAPOREGP.SG
- 14-16 AUG

F<FOREVER — 1st World Tour, Singapore Indoor Stadium

THREE NIGHTS · \$S178-398 · THE NEARER BOOKING, AHEAD OF THE OCTOBER SQUEEZE
- 3 OCT

ITZY — "Tunnel Vision" 3rd World Tour, Singapore Indoor Stadium

\$S158-358 · A GENUINELY TWEEN-FRIENDLY K-POP NIGHT IF SHE'S A FAN · CLASHES WITH THE WEEKND'S FIRST STADIUM DATE

The quarter's pinch is now on one page: The Weeknd, ITZY and Post Malone all fall in the same October window as the F1 weekend, and the first Sprint format means the race eats all three days.¹ The scarce resource is not the ticket but the hotel room the weekend a home concert collides with a Tokyo trip (p20).

THE TABLE

SINGAPORE'S NEWEST OPENINGS

BLUE BOX CAFÉ BY TIFFANY — ION ORCHARD

Opened 15 July: Tiffany & Co.'s first café in Southeast Asia, with a menu created alongside Julien Royer of three-Michelin-starred Odette — American classics through French technique, in that signature robin's-egg blue. The draw is the three-tier "Tea at Tiffany's" set (\$S98++ a head). Coverage so far is anticipation-and-aesthetics led rather than a food verdict; expect an Instagram crowd before a critics' darling. Halal status not published.

Verdict: the box sells it; the kitchen's unproven².

HYPED TOO NEW

FREAKYNOODS PASTA — CHINATOWN

Soft-launched 1 July: a daytime pasta spin-off from the ice-cream café FreakyCones, Japanese-inflected and cheekily named, with nothing over about \$S17. The signature Duck Buddy (\$S16.90) is a gochujang-cream "rosé" linguine with roast duck; Beef Daddy and Prawn Hub round it out. Early write-ups like the value and the fun, but a soft launch is a soft verdict — mains served noon to early evening only. Halal status not stated.

Verdict: fun and cheap, still finding its feet · VALUE

SOFT LAUNCH

YI MAN FEN "SUGAR RUSH" — 313@SOMERSET

July brought the first overseas outlet of a viral Chinese dessert chain — 90-plus stores across fourteen Chinese cities in about two years — trading in made-fresh sweet soups and shaved ice. Signatures run about \$S5.80: the Grand Slam 100 (milk, grass jelly, peach gum, sweet-potato balls). Known for daily sell-outs in China; locally it reads buzzy and cheap, verdict still forming.

Verdict: cheap, viral, unproven here ·

VIRAL IMPORT QUEUES

THE HYPE CHECK

Two of this week's three tables are novelty-first — a jewellery-brand café and a viral import — so hold the enthusiasm to what's actually been eaten. All three are days-to-weeks old, none has a settled critical read, and a signature blue box or a China queue is a marketing asset, not a flavour. Rested this issue with no new peg: Behind Clay, Foura and SAM SAM SAM (No. 50). Come back when the reviews, not the openings, are in.

SOURCES ¹ Bandwagon Asia (The Weeknd, 2-3 Oct, National Stadium); SassyMama SG / Singapore GP (F1 9-11 Oct, first Sprint weekend, GA from ~\$S198); Ticketmaster SG (F<FOREVER 14-16 Aug; ITZY 3 Oct), 2026. ² The Table: Eatbook / Time Out SG, 15 Jul 2026 (Blue Box Café by Tiffany, w/ Julien Royer); Eatbook, 1 Jul 2026 (FreakyNoods, soft launch); Eatbook, Jul 2026 (Yi Man Fen) — buzz summarised, verdicts flagged where too new; halal status unverified for all three.

JAPAN

THE AUTUMN CALENDAR

13–27
SEP

★ Aki Basho — Grand Sumo Autumn Tournament, Ryōgoku Kokugikan, Tokyo

15-DAY TOURNAMENT · TICKETS ON SALE 8 AUGUST · WEEKEND AND FINAL-DAY SEATS GO FIRST · GENUINELY FAMILY-FRIENDLY AND QUINTESSENTIALLY TOKYO

29–
30
AUG

Kōenji Awa Odori — Tokyo

THE 67TH EDITION · 10,000+ DANCERS, FREE STREET VIEWING, A MILLION-PLUS CROWD · GO EARLY FOR A CURB SPOT · GREAT WITH A TWEEN

10
AUG

Ghibli Park (Aichi) — October dated tickets on sale

TIMED-ENTRY OCTOBER TICKETS RELEASE 10 AUG, 2PM JST VIA LAWSON/KLOOK · SELLS OUT · SET THE ALARM IF A JAPAN TRIP IS ON THE CARDS

Picking up the thread from No. 47–48: once the summer matsuri close, the calendar rolls straight into sumo, street dance and — for a family — the two timed-entry hard-to-books, Ghibli Park and teamLab Planets, both of which sell out weeks ahead and want booking before you fly.¹ The currency maths is the one on p15: a strong Singapore dollar against a still-soft yen (USD/JPY near 165) tilts every sum toward the Tokyo traveller — and the weakness that flatters the shopping flatters the hotels too, so the good rooms clear early.

WIDER REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

19
SEP–
4
OCT

★ 2026 Asian Games — Aichi–Nagoya, Japan

43 SPORTS, 468 EVENTS · OVERLAPS A SEPTEMBER JAPAN FAMILY TRIP NEATLY · TICKETS VIA AICHI-NAGOYA2026.ORG

INTO
OCT

Busan International Film Festival — South Korea

ASIA'S LARGEST FILM FESTIVAL · PAIRS WITH THE AUTUMN-FOLIAGE WINDOW FOR A KOREA-THEN-JAPAN SWING · SEE P12

25
JUL

Sumida River Fireworks — Tokyo (tomorrow)

~20,000 FIREWORKS OVER ASAKUSA · TOO SOON TO FLY FOR — AN "IF YOU'RE ALREADY THERE" NOTE, AND ONE TO FILE FOR 2027

One autumn Japan trip can now be shaped around almost anything a family cares for — sumo and the Asian Games in mid-to-late September, Ghibli Park and teamLab in October, a Busan detour on the way. The binding constraint stays the yen: the weakness that draws this reader in draws everyone else too, so the Tokyo rooms clear well before the sumo tickets even release on 8 August.

PLANNING NOTES

September is the pinch. The Aki Basho, the Asian Games and any Tokyo hotel all compete for the same three weeks — if a Japan trip is being stitched to a home concert (p19), lock both ends before the 8 August sumo release pulls the Tokyo inventory.

Family-friendly: the earlier days of the basho, Kōenji's daytime dancing and Ghibli Park travel best with an eleven-year-old; late-night arena shows, less so.

THE HAND-OFF

This is where the book's travel thread lands each week: the Macro Desk sets the currency (p15), The Good Life the objects — and now the suites — worth flying for (p11), and The Diary the dated events to actually book. There is no Grand Tour deep dive on a weekday briefing — that supplement runs only on the weekend — but the arithmetic it would use is on every page here: a firm Singapore dollar, a soft yen, and an autumn calendar that rewards booking early over booking well.

FURTHER OUT · ALREADY ON THE CALENDAR

F1 Singapore Grand Prix (9–11 Oct) — the full entertainment bill was locked in No. 48; the race weekend is the fixed point the October squeeze forms around (p19). **ZoukOut 2026** (2–3 Dec, Siloso Beach) — the festival's 20th anniversary, with Carl Cox, Armin van Buuren and Martin Garrix; early-bird tickets flagged in No. 48. **ENHYPEN** — the group's first National Stadium show (14 Mar 2027) went to membership presale in July (No. 43); general sale is the next peg. Carried forward as continuity, not re-explained.²

SOURCES ¹ Japan Travel / Nihon Sumo Kyokai (Aki Basho 13–27 Sep, tickets 8 Aug); Tokyo Cheapo (Kōenji Awa Odori 29–30 Aug); Ghibli Park official (October tickets on sale 10 Aug); teamLab Planets / Klook, 2026; USD/JPY via MTFX / TradingEconomics, Jul 2026. ² Aichi–Nagoya 2026 Asian Games (19 Sep–4 Oct); Busan International Film Festival, 2026; F1 lineup, ZoukOut and ENHYPEN carried from No. 43/48 — no new peg this issue.

THE LONG READ · THE UNDERCURRENT

The Pain Bag

The West wrote ten thousand words on the Labubu and missed the iceberg beneath it: a twenty-four-billion-dollar Chinese economy built on selling young people feelings, whose viral emblem is a bag deliberately worn until it hurts to look at. What China's youth are buying instead of the future their parents bought.

Start with the object, because the object explains everything. A *tòngbāo* — literally a "pain bag," 痛包 — is a handbag or backpack whose owner has covered its clear front panel in enamel pins, acrylic charms and photo cards of a single beloved character or idol, packed so densely that the effect tips past decoration into something almost aggressive.¹ The name is the point: 痛 means "painful," and the bag is meant to be worn until the devotion on display becomes, by the wearer's own cheerful admission, a little too much — cringe, excessive, *painful* to a stranger's eye. It is fandom turned inside out. Where an earlier generation hid its obsessions, this one armours itself in them and walks into the street. On Xiaohongshu, China's Instagram, the hashtag has drawn a reported 2.3 billion views, and mentions of the format have been climbing roughly 95% a quarter.²

The pain bag is the visible tip of something the Western press has almost entirely missed. Over the past two years it wrote the Labubu to death — the gremlin-faced Pop Mart doll that queued shoppers around the block from London to Bangkok — and treated it as a toy story, a viral-product story, a single hit. What it did not see is the system underneath: *guzi* (谷子), a word that is simply the Mandarin phoneticisation of the English "goods," and which now names an entire economy of character merchandise — pins, cards, standees, acrylics, plushies — that Chinese consumers, overwhelmingly young and mostly female, buy not for utility and not quite for status, but for what they openly call 情绪价值: emotional value.³

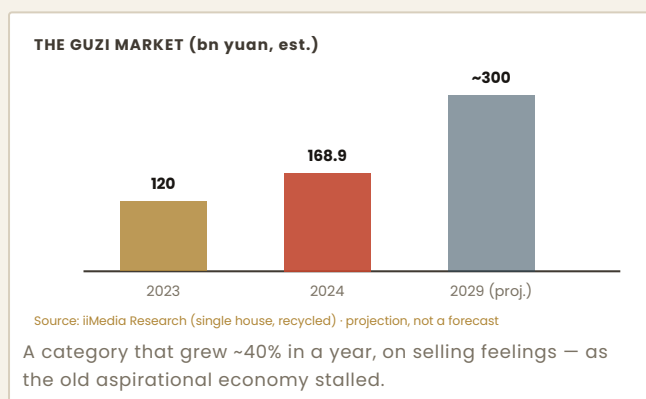
Where an earlier generation hid its obsessions, this one armours itself in them and walks into the street. The name says it all: worn until it's painful to look at.

The scale is the part that should stop a Western editor. By the most-cited industry estimate the guzi market reached 168.9 billion yuan in 2024 — roughly US\$24 billion — having grown more than 40% in a single year, with projections running past 300 billion yuan by 2029.⁴ (One caveat worth flagging: nearly every number in circulation traces to a single research house, iiMedia, recycled across outlets, so treat the precision as softer than it looks.) That is not a toy line. That is a consumer category the size of a mid-tier national industry, built almost entirely on selling young people a feeling — and it has arrived precisely as the older Chinese aspirational economy, the one their parents knew, has stalled.

This is the argument worth making, and it is not the one the Labubu coverage reached for. For the generation now in its twenties, the big-ticket ladder that organised Chinese adult life — an apartment, a car, a wedding, a stable career in a work unit — has become, for many, unreachable: youth unemployment sits near 16%, the property boom that minted a middle class has deflated, and the confidence that underwrote all of it has thinned. When the large aspiration closes off, aspiration does not vanish. It redirects — downward, and inward. The money that a decade ago went toward a deposit now goes, in small and frequent doses, into a pin, a blind box, a photo card. A feeling you can afford, bought again and again, in place of a future you cannot.

SOURCES 1 SCMP "Trending China," "How a 'painful bag' became a popular subculture," 2026; RADII, "The painful price of fandom: the ita-bag craze." 2 Xiaohongshu hashtag figure via SCMP / WalktheChat, 2026 (view count reported; exact date unstated — flagged). 3 Daoinsights, "What is the guzi economy and why is it surging?"; PandaYoo, "China's billion-dollar mood booster." 4 iiMedia Research, cited by China Daily (12 Aug 2025) and People's Daily (6 Mar 2026): guzi ≈168.9bn yuan in 2024, +40.63% YoY, projected ~300bn by 2029 — single research house, recycled; treat as indicative.

There is a neat historical irony buried in the word itself. The practice is Japanese in origin — the *ita-bag*, from *itai* ("painful"), was a Tokyo fan ritual long before it was a Chinese phenomenon, and "guzi" is nothing more than the English "goods" bent through Mandarin. China imported the vocabulary and the habit. What China then did was what China does: it industrialised them. A cottage practice of devoted fans became a supply chain with factories, listed companies and an IPO pipeline.¹ The clearest case is Kayou, the trading-card giant whose Ultraman and anime packs gave it something like a 71% share of China's card market and 2024 revenue above ten billion yuan at a net margin north of 40% — numbers that sent it toward a Hong Kong listing.² Pop Mart, the Labubu company, is merely the most globally visible node of a network that also runs through Miniso's stores and a resale market on Xianyu where more than seven in ten guzi transactions are made by people born after 1995.



Who is buying, and why, is where the story stops being cute. The guzi shopper skews young, urban and female — by one estimate young women make up around 61% of buyers, most in the biggest cities — and the language they and the platforms use to describe the purchase is telling.³ They speak not of collecting or investing but of 陪伴, companionship, and 情绪价值, emotional value; one widely-shared survey reported that some 83% of respondents felt a sense of "companionship" from their guzi.⁴ (That figure, like much of the sentiment data here, comes from secondary Chinese-finance coverage and

should be read as reported, not measured.) This is not conspicuous consumption in the old sense of signalling wealth to strangers. It is closer to self-medication you can hold — a small, repeatable purchase that reliably delivers a hit of comfort in a year that has been short on it.

China imported the vocabulary and the habit from Japan, then did what China does: it industrialised a fan ritual into a supply chain with factories, listed companies and an IPO pipeline.

The surest sign that a Chinese subculture has arrived is that the state decides to approve of it, and that moment came this summer. In June, both People's Daily and Xinhua ran explainers on 情绪消费 — "emotional consumption" — framing the whole phenomenon not as frivolity to be curbed but as a growth engine to be encouraged.⁵ The subtext is not hard to read. In an economy where the property developers are wounded and the consumer is cautious, the emotional economy is one of the very few places where young people still reliably open their wallets. A government desperate for domestic demand will take spending wherever it can find it — even if what is being sold is, in the end, a feeling.

And the feeling is spreading past the bag. The Chinese-language business press now documents the escalation of 痛 culture from the *tòngbào* to the 痛桌 (the pain-desk, a workspace buried in figures), the 痛房 (the pain-room), even the 痛车 and, half-jokingly, the 痛厕所 — a culture of 痛一切, "paining everything," coating every surface of one's life in the evidence of an obsession.⁶ When a fashion for decorated handbags becomes a philosophy of decorating one's entire physical world, it has stopped being a trend and become a way of living inside a feeling — which is exactly what makes it worth watching, and worth doubting.

SOURCES 1 On the Japanese *ita-bag* origin and the "goods → 谷子" loan: WalktheChat; RADII, 2026. 2 Kayou IPO coverage: Bamboo Works; kr-asia; Reuters (via TradingView), 2025 — 2024 revenue ~10.06bn yuan, net margin >40%, ~71% card-market share, ~US\$500m HK IPO; Xianyu resale >70% post-95s via China Daily. 3 Jing Daily / People's Daily, 2026 (buyer demographics ~61% young women). 4 Sina Finance, 18 Feb 2026 (83.08% "companionship" — secondary coverage, reported not measured). 5 Xinhua and People's Daily, 7 Jun 2026 ("情绪消费" emotional-consumption explainers). 6 CBNDdata; The Paper (澎湃), 2026 ("痛一切" escalation to 痛桌/痛房/痛车 — headlines attested, internal figures unverified).

It would be easy, and wrong, to end there — on a tidy story of a plucky youth culture inventing joy amid hard times. The doubts are real and they are several. The first is a plain bubble worry: a category growing 40% a year on a single research house's projections invites the usual scepticism, and China Daily's own coverage already concedes that guzi shops now sit "in every mall," that early entrants are closing, and asks openly whether the emotional value can sustain the expansion.¹ A feeling is a renewable resource; retail space and disposable income are not.

The second doubt is darker, and it is why the regulators moved. The engine of much of this is the blind box — the sealed package whose contents are a gamble, engineered to trigger the exact reward loop a slot machine uses. One consultancy calls the trading-card version "miniature gambling for China's Gen Alpha," and the state agreed enough to act: new rules bar blind-box sales to children under eight, require parental consent for those aged eight to seventeen, and mandate that odds be disclosed, after a People's Daily editorial warned of "addiction" among the young.² An economy that runs on engineered compulsion in the pockets of teenagers is not a wholesome one, whatever comfort it also delivers — a caution that rhymes, uncomfortably, with the screen-and-compulsion evidence two desks over (p13).

A feeling is a renewable resource; retail space and disposable income are not. The question is whether this is a culture, or a coping mechanism that contracts the moment the mood lifts.

The third doubt is that some of the "spontaneous youth movement" is manufactured — pushed hard by malls that need footfall, by brands like Miniso running "it's-everything" campaigns, and by platforms that monetise every view. And the fourth, the deepest, is fragility. If guzi is fundamentally a

coping mechanism — cheap dopamine standing in for a stalled future — then it is hostage to the very mood it soothes. Let confidence return, let the property market or the job market heal, and the emotional economy could deflate as fast as it inflated, revealed in hindsight as a symptom rather than a sector. The pain bag may turn out to be less a new consumer paradigm than an emotional readout of a particular anxious moment.

But symptom or sector, it is already crossing borders, and that is the part a Singapore reader should mark. The format is being re-exported — Miniso and Pop Mart are carrying guzi retailing into an ASEAN anime market worth over a billion dollars, into Indonesia, Vietnam, Thailand and, yes, here.³ Japan invented the vocabulary; China industrialised and financialised it; and it is now China, not Japan, exporting the emotional economy as a cultural product. That reversal is the quiet geopolitical fact under the cute one: soft power used to travel as film and music, the polished official face of a culture; this travels as something rawer and more revealing — the coping mechanism of a generation, sold as a lifestyle. When the *Financial Times* runs "China's Gen Z is buying feelings, not things" a few weeks from now — and it will — the thing to remember is that the story was never really about a doll. It was about what a generation does with the aspiration it can no longer spend the old way: it buys, in a thousand small painful pieces, the feeling the future used to promise.

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What will decide whether guzi is a sector or a symptom: whether the mall build-out keeps pace with spending or starts closing (China Daily already reports early exits); whether the blind-box crackdown deepens once the "addiction" framing meets the "growth-engine" framing head-on; and whether Southeast Asian sales stick once the novelty cools. Reported here from the accessible layer — What's on Weibo, Sixth Tone, Caixin, SCMP, Nikkei Asia and the Chinese business press — with sentiment attributed, not measured, and the single-research-house caveat on every market figure. The next thing the West writes up; you read it first.

SOURCES 1 China Daily, "Gen Z's craze for guzi," 12 Aug 2025 (guzi stores "in every mall," early closures, sustainability question). 2 Double V Consulting, "Are trading cards miniature gambling for China's Gen Alpha?"; SCMP / China Daily HK / CNBC (4 Jul 2025) on the blind-box crackdown — under-8 ban, 8–17 parental consent, odds disclosure; People's Daily "addiction" editorial (Jun 2025). 3 Alibaba Seller SEA white paper, 2026 (ASEAN anime market ~US\$1.3bn); RADII (Miniso/Pop Mart SEA expansion). Essay reporting from the accessible English/translated layer; sentiment attributed as reported; market figures trace to iiMedia Research (single house).

Two prices moved this week, and they rhyme. In the Gulf, oil broke a hundred dollars a barrel because the world will pay almost anything for the certainty that its cargo arrives — a premium on confidence, charged at gunpoint. In China, a generation that can no longer afford the apartment and the career its parents bought is spending instead, in a thousand small painful pieces, on the feeling the future used to promise — a premium on comfort, paid to itself. One is scarcity of oil; the other, scarcity of hope. Both are people pricing what they cannot be sure of. The barrel will settle when the strait quiets. The harder question is what settles the other.

CONSOLIDATED SOURCES — NO. 51

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The Long Read (The Undercurrent): SCMP, RADII, DaoInsights, PandaYoo, iiMedia (via China Daily / People's Daily), WalktheChat, Bamboo Works, kr-asia, Jing Daily, Sina Finance, Xinhua, People's Daily, CBNDData, The Paper (澎湃), Double V Consulting, CNBC, Alibaba Seller SEA.